We batted first and I was the first to get out for 31 to Ata-ur-Rehman, the Pakistan fast bowler, trying to steer the ball to third man. Navjot Sidhu, who opened the batting with me, batted well for his 93 and Ajay Jadeja played a fantastic cameo towards the end, scoring 45 off twenty-five balls to get us to a very respectable 287 in our fifty overs.

Pakistan started brightly in response and raced to 80 in their first ten overs. We badly needed a wicket to keep the scoring in check and that's when a famous incident took place involving Aamer Sohail, the Pakistan opener, and Venkatesh Prasad, our fast-medium bowler. Sohail had hit Venky for a boundary towards point and suggested rather aggressively that that was where he wanted to keep Venky all day. He waved his bat towards the boundary and said a number of rather rude things. Venky, understandably angry, bowled him with his very next ball. It was sweet revenge. Having got his man, it was now his turn and he showed Aamer Sohail the way to the dressing room.

The team was pumped up after this incident and we soon took control of the match. Prasad picked up two more crucial wickets and Ajay Jadeja and I bowled ten reasonably tight overs between us in the middle, while Kumble chipped in with three wickets. In what turned out to be his final international innings, Javed Miandad was run out for 38, ending a glorious career for Pakistan. Despite some good late hitting by wicketkeeper Rashid Latif, which caused us a bit of a panic, we were on the ascendancy throughout and in the end won the match fairly comfortably, by 39 runs, prompting celebrations all over the country.

On our way back to the hotel we could see people lining the streets and they were throwing garlands and flowers at the team bus. In the hotel too we were being treated differently. We stayed on in Bangalore for one extra day and spent a relaxed few hours in the pool the next afternoon. We could sense that the staff were trying to please us and were looking at us differently. They were looking after our every need and when somebody ordered prawns, three different varieties were served, all on the house. We were being treated like royalty and it felt wonderful to see the country so happy and proud.

Things fall apart

We were due to play Sri Lanka in the semi-final at Eden Gardens on 13 March. We arrived in Kolkata two days before and the first thing that